Another common practice is restricting access to specific proceedings and documents. This can be achieved through classification systems, encryption, or limited distribution methods. The WTO, for example, uses stand-alone computers accessible only in person to minimize data breaches. Similarly, the IMF classifies many documents in its archives, keeping them inaccessible to the public for extended periods. Liability mechanisms also deter unauthorized leaks, further reinforcing the confidentiality of such processes.

At the other end of the spectrum lies complete secrecy, where IOs refuse to produce or disclose certain documents altogether. This approach is frequently used in high-stakes areas like security or arbitration. For instance, many cases at the International Centre for Settlement of Investment Disputes remain fully opaque, depending on the transparency preferences of panelists (Hafner-Burton, Steinert-Threlkeld, and Victor 2016). In the security domain, sensitive information is often shared only under strict confidentiality guarantees, enabling states to cooperate without fear of exposure.

Some IOs also adopt hybrid approaches, combining transparent and opaque elements. WTO dispute-settlement procedures, for instance, allow for private bargaining sessions before or instead of formal adjudication. Similarly, the IMF might publicly share broad economic data about a country while withholding more sensitive details, such as those related to banking stability.

It may seem implausible that IOs shield interactions with populist-led states from public scrutiny or other member states. Some IOs, such as the United Nations, have been criticized for leaks (Taylor 1991), and their staffing by member-state nationals might appear to complicate confidentiality. However, certain IOs have demonstrated strong track records in maintaining secrecy. The IAEA, for example, has consistently upheld nuclear confidentiality, earning trust through decades of reliable secret-keeping. IOs also safeguard information to protect international norms, preserve state security (Busch and Pelc 2010; Coe and Vaynman 2020), and ensure that proprietary data remain confidential (Hafner-Burton, Steinert-Threlkeld, and Victor 2016).

The likelihood of leaks significantly influences populists' willingness to engage covertly. When the risk is low, populists are more inclined to